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Myth vs Legend

I sat alone in my office for the better part of an hour. I was patient, at first. It was no surprise that the trio needed time. It had been a bad couple of minutes for them in any number of ways. But patience soon gave way to aggravation, and then to worry.

What the hell was going on out there? Had one or more of the women been hurt? I kept telling myself that Danni would have come back if that were the case, but I really couldn't be sure.

Then, just as I reached the point where I couldn't take it anymore, Liv arrived. Alone.

"Where are the others?" I asked.

My words came out sharper than they should have. I was annoyed that they couldn't even seem to do this right.

"I asked them to let me talk to you alone."

Her sad tone and *hat in hand* posture blunted my anger.

"Why?" I asked.

"Because I want to apologize."

The next thirty seconds were a struggle for me. All of my natural instincts told me to slap her. To tell her how stupid she'd been and that it was too late for an apology. But I let those thoughts play through my head without saying a word. Waiting for my common sense to kick in. When it did, I realized something was very off about all of this.

"Because your smart mouth got you in trouble? Is that why you're sorry? Because you got your ass kicked?"

Considering the humiliation she'd already suffered, this was a bit like rubbing salt in the wound. But the questions were serious. One thing I had to accept was that these three women were a mystery to me. If I was ever going to get through to them, I needed to unravel that. Starting with understanding how this young woman who'd so boldly gotten in my face only a short time ago was suddenly showing such humility.

Liv's cheeks flushed with embarrassment, but she didn't respond right away. When she did, she didn't answer me directly.

"I shouldn't have done what I did," she said. "It was stupid. I knew it was stupid when I was doing it."

"But you did it, anyway."

"Yeah. I don't know why."

It was an interesting admission, but it didn't do much for me.

“That’s not good enough. I need to know why. I need to understand what the hell you were thinking, and I need you to help me with that.”

Again the color rose in her cheeks.

“I was showing off.”

“For who?”

“Dove and Z, I guess.”

“You guess?”

“I don’t know,” she pouted. “Maybe for you? I don’t know.”

I flashed back to when I was a little girl. The way my father would browbeat me after I’d done something stupid and force me to explain myself. That was always the most humiliating part. Having to explain why I did some idiotic thing when I knew it was idiotic before I did it.

That humiliation I felt then was reflected in the expression I saw on Liv’s face now, and it made me realize something.

“How much of it was for you?” I asked.

She looked up at me for the first time since she’d entered the office.

“Some, I guess,” she admitted.

Again, I drifted back. Not as far this time. I thought about the decisions I’d made when I was Liv’s age. The way I’d gotten myself tangled up in the morass of seedy venues and greedy operators that made up the underground circuit. It was probably the stupidest thing I’d ever done, and the logical part of me had known it before I even started. So why had I done it? The answer wasn’t clear back then, but now I knew. To prove myself. Not to others, but to me. To show myself that I could. It was easy to see that now because I had gained the confidence to know I could. But back then, all I had was fear and irrational fortitude.

Meanwhile, I suddenly felt like I had my first inkling regarding what was going on here. Enough that it was time to get the group back together and test my theory.

“Tell me again why the other two aren’t here,” I said.

“Like I said, I wanted the chance to apologize.”

“And they don’t think they have anything to apologize for?”

“No, that’s...” she said hurriedly. “This was my idea. I started what happened. They wanted to come, but I said no.”

I didn’t necessarily believe that. They may have been willing to come, but I seriously doubted they wanted to.

“They were just as much a part of it as you.”

“Yeah, but I put the idea in their heads.”

I thought about the way I’d watched Liv’s little brainstorm spread to the other two. Either one of them could have tried to stop what was happening, but they’d immediately joined in instead. All facts that fit with my nascent theory.

“Go get them,” I said.

“I... they shouldn’t get in trouble for this.”

“Part of showing humility is taking what’s coming to you while recognizing that you don’t call the shots,” I said sternly. “Now, go get them.”

She left without further argument. While she was gone, I went over to Danni’s office to steal an extra chair. I spent some time thinking things over as I did it.

There is a *hive mind* mentality that comes with being a teenager. A willingness to do and say what everyone else is doing and saying simply so you can be part of the group. Because, for whatever reason, doing stupid things together is preferable to trying to think for yourself.

The phenomenon lessens as we get older, but it never goes away completely. As we learn, we develop our own ideas and the conviction to stand for them, but there are still situations where we lack the knowledge and confidence to make our own decisions. When that happens, we quickly revert back to the go-with-the-flow approach.

Here I had three young women who had repeatedly shown tremendous confidence and poise in situations where I wouldn’t know which end was up. Having their faces beamed into millions of homes, where they would be judged on everything from the way they looked to the sound of their voice to the way they walked across the damn room. Facing the press and the endless questions about those same inane topics while never letting their pretty smiles falter.

So what the hell was wrong with them now? Well, confidence and poise come from experience and understanding, and they didn’t have that here. Cameras and microphones might not faze them, but cages and heavy bags were not yet in their wheelhouse. So, it wasn’t surprising that they were uncomfortable. It’s why there were three of them instead of just one. Because we’d had this brilliant idea that it would be better if they had each other to lean on. We hoped they would bond and gel together, and that’s exactly what they’d done. When Liv got it in her head to challenge me, the other two had immediately joined in. Not because they’d given it careful consideration and decided it was a good idea, but because whatever they did they needed to do together.

In other words, we had accidentally opened the door for the *hive mind* to return.

But was that really so bad? The way Zendaya and Dove had stood behind their friend... isn’t that what everyone here does?

I didn’t have to think very hard to come up with a list of examples.

Britney and Leesh.

Emma and Tiffany.

Danni and I.

I thought a bit about what Danni's support did for me, and immediately came to a conclusion.

The problem wasn't that Liv, Daya and Dove were doing the wrong thing. It's that they were doing the right thing the wrong way.

My thoughts were interrupted as the three marched into my office like prisoners on a chain. I kept my demeanor neutral as I undid their imaginary shackles with a wave of my hand.

"Sit," I said as I gestured them into the chairs.

They sat and we all spent a few moments staring at each other.

"Are we all in agreement that what happened earlier should not have?" I asked eventually.

Three heads nodded solemnly.

"And we all regret that it did?"

More nodding.

"Alright, then I think we should put that behind us."

Nobody disagreed as the three seemed to breathe a collective sigh of relief.

"So, that brings us to the all-important question... now what?"

They all looked at each other, but nobody said anything.

"Don't all shout out at once," I said.

Liv, who was quickly becoming the de facto leader of the trio, was the first to speak.

"We don't know," she said.

I nodded evenly.

"That's going to be an important thing to keep in mind for the rest of this conversation."

They looked confused, but still none of them said anything.

"You three realize the effort we've been putting into you?"

All three stiffened. Girding themselves for the onslaught they figured was coming, which told me they'd been expecting this moment for a while.

“We’re not getting much return on our investment,” I said.

“We’re not happy, either,” Liv responded.

“No. I would imagine not.”

“We know everyone is trying to help,” she said. “It’s depressing, really.”

“They can’t help you if you don’t listen.”

“We listen,” she protested.

“No. You may hear what they say, but you don’t listen. You’re too busy screwing around. The three of you remind me of high school kids. Always carrying on like idiots instead of paying attention in class.”

The silence returned along with the chastened expressions.

“You want to tell me why you do that?”

No response. This was like pulling teeth.

“Again, please don’t talk over each other.”

“Because it’s easier,” Liv blurted out.

“Easier than what?”

“Than looking stupid.”

I paused. Letting my eyes travel from face to face.

“You’re worried about looking stupid?”

No answer. I looked at Zendaya and Dove.

“You two know how to talk, or what?”

“We feel the same as Liv,” Dove replied as the brunette nodded beside her.

The *hive mind* speaks.

I turned back to Olivia.

“You don’t think you look stupid when you get in the cage unprepared?”

“Sure we do, but...”

“But what?”

Nothing.

“Somebody here giving you static?”

Great. I’m talking to kids half my age, using phrases that predate my existence.

“Static?” Daya asked incredulously.

I glared at her.

“Really? NOW you’re gonna talk?” I said.

She stopped cold and said no more.

I went from face to face again, then spread my hands out wide.

“Well, somebody better start saying something.”

“What do you want us to say?” Liv asked.

“Explain what the hell you’re talking about. All three of you went into that cage last week looking like you’d landed there by accident. How much stupider can you look?”

“It’s not the same...”

“The same as WHAT?”

“As looking stupid in front of our teammates.”

I’m guessing my expression made it clear I still didn’t get it because she quickly continued.

“Emily VanCamp. Ashley Tisdale. Anna Kendrick. Jennifer Lawrence,” she said. “I mean, geez... that’s Emma Watson, out there!”

“I don’t...”

My words trailed off as I noticed the others nodding emphatically. Like Liv had finally given voice to the weight that was hanging around their necks.

And that’s when it clicked.

It seemed *starstruck* didn’t really cover how these three felt about their teammates.

RSI had been here so long, I no longer thought much about the combined success and celebrity these walls contained. To me they were teammates. All part of a big family of equals.

But, to these three, the women here were everything they wanted to be. Many of them - most notably Emma - had taken the very same path this trio was trying to follow. From adorable little Hermione to the independent and daring young woman she was today, Em made the turn so many child stars fail to negotiate. She had navigated the very same rough waters these three were now trying to sail, and she had done it with a grace and self-assuredness that was practically unheard of.

These women were currently going through what might end up being the most difficult change in their lives. A time when past success meant almost nothing and the future was far from certain. To them, Emma and the others were much more than teammates. They were heroes of a sort. Living symbols of the success they hoped to achieve, both in and out of the cage. Looking at it that way, it was easy to see how these three might be feeling more than a little intimidated.

Seemed to me what I needed to do was make it clear to them that the rules are different within these walls. And I knew just the right person to help me do that.

I picked up the phone on my desk and pressed the button for the internal line to the training area.

“How’s it going?” Danni answered.

“You wouldn’t believe me if I told you,” I said. “Emma still beating you up, or can I grab her for a second?”

“Go fuck yourself,” she said evenly. Then, “I can free her up, if you need her.”

“Good. Send her in.”

A couple of beats ticked by.

“What are you up to?”

“I’ll bring you up to speed later,” I replied. “Like I said, you won’t believe it.”

We hung up, and I looked at the three in front of me. They’d heard enough of my end to know Emma was coming, and now they all had that deer-in-the-headlights look.

“Oh, lighten up,” I said. “It’s just Emma.”

Less than a minute later, Ms. Watson stuck her head into my office.

“You rang?” she asked.

Whatever she’d been doing, it had been strenuous. She was breathing a little heavier than normal, and - though she’d already mopped herself off with the towel that was slung over her shoulder - rivulets of perspiration ran down her face and neck. She was wearing compression shorts and a matching sports bra, both colored black with scarlet and gold highlights.

I looked her attire up and down and quickly recognized the hidden reference in the color pattern.

“Ten points to Gryffindor,” I declared with a wry smile.

The rookies giggled as Emma’s widely-recognized smirk appeared.

“How are you the first to notice?”

“Because the others are uncultured swine.”

“Or you’re just a dork.”

“You’re the one wearing the outfit.”

She smirked again, then conceded my point with a subtle nod.

“So, what’s up?” she asked.

I gestured toward the younger fighters and said, “The youth here seem to be having a little trouble adjusting to life here at RSI.”

“You adjusted them pretty good a little while ago.”

The three all turned the same shade of crimson.

“You’re not helping,” I said.

“Sorry,” she said. “What do you need from me?”

“I was hoping maybe you can give them an idea of how things work.”

She turned and looked at the rookies in confusion, then turned her puzzled expression back on me.

“What?” she asked.

“The aspiring young starlets seem to be having some difficulty dealing with the level of celebrity around here. Seems a few of their teammates make their knees go weak,” I said.

“Ah,” she said with a nod.

“I think they need a better understanding of what happens when you walk through that door.”

The women of RSI all share one common trait. No matter how successful or popular they are outside these walls, each of them struggled once they got inside. It was worse for some than others, and, believe it or not, Emma was among those who’d had the most difficulty. In fact, it turned out there were a lot of things bubbling underneath her calm surface. That the pressure of simply being her was not as easily handled as she made it seem. The problems with Tiff then became the trigger that set off an explosion of nuclear proportions, and everyone here got hit with the fallout.

When the dust settled, I made it clear to Em that RSI was not a place where she needed to keep up appearances the way she had to elsewhere. To put it bluntly, *what happens here, stays here* is the unwritten mantra of Rampage Sports, and anyone who violates that code will find herself out on her ass in short order.

That assurance seemed to provide the footing she needed because she’s been on the upslope of what looks to be a long and successful MMA career ever since. On top of that, she’s now got this part of her life just as squarely under her thumb as everything else. So, who better to explain to the new kids how it works than the woman who’d traveled all the way from rock bottom to the top of the heap? A woman they all happened to look up to, anyway.

What I hadn't anticipated was just how she would decide to teach them.

"Sure, I'd be happy to talk to them," she said, "but you're going to have to leave."

It took a second for that to register.

"I... are you throwing me out of my own office?"

She shrugged.

"We could move to the conference room if you want, but we're already here."

I stared at her in disbelief as I let the idea play through my head. It was a ballsy request, but I've come to realize that ballsy is something Emma does better than you'd think. And she had a point. Her audience was already assembled. Plus, granting the request would probably be good for at least a month of sarcastic remarks about her lack of respect. So, the idea had merit.

But still...

"You got fuckin' nerve, Watson."

She threw her hands up in mock surrender.

"Hey, I said we'd move."

Yeah, she said it, but I didn't see her making any effort to actually do it.

I kept my eyes on her and shook my head in disdain as I stood. I maintained the glare throughout my path around the desk, then turned to look at the younger three.

"If she sits in my chair, you tell me," I instructed them.

They had some trouble hiding their amusement at the situation.

I shook my head at Emma again.

"Fuckin' NERVE," I repeated, then stepped out, closing the door behind me.

Unwilling to stand in my own lobby like some kind of visitor, I made my way back to the training area.

I had a feeling I knew what Emma was doing. I'd called on her because of what happened back when, hoping the experience would help her connect with what the rookies were going through. But now, I suspected she was telling them the actual story, warts and all.

It was an interesting call. Not only would she be able to explain the unwritten code, but she would essentially knock herself off her own perch in the process. Show the younger fighters that even the vaunted Emma Watson can crack under the strain.

Still, it surprised me how quickly she decided to go that route. Those events were so out of character for Emma... I can't imagine it was easy for her to talk about.

I wandered back to where the teams were working, this time finding Aly in the sparring cage. The similarities with Emma's earlier approach were immediately obvious. First of all, she appeared to be going for broke as she traded vicious blows with her sparring partner. Second, that partner was once again Danni.

With nothing else to do, I hung around for a long time, spending every minute fighting the urge to make them stop. I was sure something terrible was going to happen, but neither of them seemed too concerned. In fact, they seemed to relish the way they were punishing each other.

Something was clearly going on here, and I suspected I knew what it was. For now, though, I decided to let the big girls play.

Nearly forty minutes after I left them, the three rookies returned to the gym. Each gave a little nod, then continued on past me.

Emma sidled up beside me.

"Not only did you commandeer my office, but you dismissed my charges without my consent," I said.

"They'll be waiting for you in the cage," she said. "Try not to kill them, this time."

"I didn't kill them last time."

"Yeah, but you tried."

Certainly that wasn't true. If I had really tried, they'd be dead.

"You told them about what happened back when?"

She nodded lightly.

"How much do they know?"

"Enough."

"You tell them about how I found you and Tiffany in the cage, denuded and copulating?"

"No," she said flatly. "I left that part out."

I nodded.

"I suppose not all the details were necessarily pertinent to today's lesson."

"Indeed, not."

I let it go at that and turned more serious.

"I didn't expect you to tell them that story," I said. "I feel bad that you had to relive it."

She shrugged.

“I have to relive it in my head all the time. No point keeping it a secret if it can help,” she said. “Besides, they stick around long enough, they’ll hear about it eventually.”

I nodded. That’s the flip-side of *what happens here, stays here*.

Outside this building, Emma’s struggles and the events surrounding them were pure myth. They never happened.

Within these walls, it is the stuff of legend.

“You think they’ll stick around?”

“Sure. I think they get it now.”

I turned and eyed her suspiciously.

“Get what?”

“The way things work around here. I think they’re starting to realize how good they have it.”

I eyed her some more.

“That almost sounded like a compliment.”

“Mmm-hmm,” she nodded, “and here’s another one - you did a nice job figuring them out. The way they were behaving, I never would have guessed, but you’re pretty good at that stuff.”

“Sure,” I snorted. “Only took me a year.”

“Fair point,” she said. “Besides... we wouldn’t want you getting delusions of adequacy or anything.”

Don’t you just want to slap her, sometimes?

“There’s the insult I’ve been waiting for,” I said cheerfully. “Thanks. I feel better.”

“My pleasure,” she said.